Son of Rumpelstiltskin

By AJ Jacobs

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INTRODUCTION

Set against the backdrop of an enchanted forest, this is the timeless story of a magical, though temperamental, little creature named Rumpelstiltskin who longs for recognition and power. He entices a young maiden to pledge to him her firstborn child in exchange for turning straw into gold. And as it true with most fairy tales the story repeats itself throughout generations . . . Son of Rumpelstiltskin by AJ Jacobs.

Once a very long time ago, In a forest, there was a tree-which is a nice thing to have in a forest. Now, in this tree there happened to live a funny little man in a green suit with a pointed cap. He lived with his son-also a funny little man in a green suit with a pointed cap.

One day the son walked over to his father's side of the branch with a question he had been wondering about for fifty years. (He hadn't wanted to rush things.)

"How come we've got to live in a tree?" he asked.

"Because we're not ordinary folks, boy," replied the older little man, wagging his wisdom-filled finger. "We're magic."

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"Magic?"

"Yup," said the father. "You know how sometimes folks get into trouble and then they meet a funny little man who makes a deal to help 'em out? And he does a little magic and then later on, they write a fairy tale about it?" He pulled a fairy-tale book out of his cap. and pointed to some funny little men. "Funny little men. That's us."

And then, being that it was the son's six hundredth birthday, the father told him it was time he go out in the world and make a name for himself.

"If I do real good," asked the son, "will they write a fairy tale about me?"

"Without a doubt," said the father, who then gave his son a helpful kick on the rear to start him on his way. Off went the son to make a name for himself and, with any luck, sell his life story to a fairy-tale agent for a goodly sum.

In the village nearby, there was a miller who was very poor, but as luck would have it, he had a very beautiful daughter. One day the miller's daughter was carrying a load of flour when who should she bump into but the king himself, out for his daily constitutional. The king was knocked on his royal rear, but before he could gather his thoughts and banish the girl from the kingdom forever, the miller bounded to the rescue.

"This daughter of mine can spin gold out of straw," boasted the miller. He pointed to his lovely flaxen-haired girl.

"Spin gold out of straw?" exclaimed the king, his regal red eyebrows arching. "Bring this girl to my castle tomorrow and if she can do as you say, I shall take her for my bride. Good day."

The king marched off to do royal things, such as sit on his throne and behead people, leaving the father and daughter alone.

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"Father, what did you tell him a thing like that for?" cried the daughter.

"So that he'll marry you and we can live in a palace in comfort and every whim catered to, including dental care," said the miller.

"But I can't spin gold out of straw-you know that!"

"Yeah, I know it. And you know it. But the king doesn't know it! And we sure won't tell him!" The miller laughed loudly at his own wit, leaving the daughter with no choice but to bonk him on the head with a sack of flour.

The next morning, the king placed the unfortunate miller's daughter in a dark room in the castle with nothing but a spinning wheel and a stack of straw. "Now spin that straw to gold-or else!" ordered the king. Thereupon, he thoughtfully gave the girl her privacy by gently closing the door and nailing it shut.

Alone in the room, the miller's daughter sat down and put her chin in her hands. "I don't want to be or *elsed*"

The funny little man in the green suit with a pointed cap-the one trying to make a name for himself-'had heard about the young girl's plight, and knew that this was the chance that he had been waiting for. So into the room he hopped.

"Who are you?" exclaimed the girl.

"I'm a funny little man in a green suit."

"You could say that again."

"I'm a funny little man in a-"

"Never mind," said the daughter, who had no time for such shenanigans. After all, she was busy doing nothing. "What do you want'?" she asked.

"I will spin that straw to gold for you if you will give me your first child after you become queen."

"My first child? Why that?"

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"Who knows?" The little man shrugged. "Makes the plot better."

Not one to interfere with the plot, the miller's daughter shook hands with the little man. He jumped to the wheel and in no time at "all had spun a room full of bright, shimmering gold. When in the morning the king found everything as he had wished, he was overjoyed. He now had so much money he could be king. That is, if he weren't king already.

They were married, and the miller's daughter became queen. She was given a throne right next to her husband, and learned to sit for long periods of time, as kings and queens do.

About two years afterward, a beautiful child was born and the little man appeared in the castle once again.

"Hi! I came for the kid," he said.

The queen jumped back and clutched her child to her chest.

"But you can't have my child! What will you do with him?"

"Dress him in a green suit and make a funny little old man out of him. What else?"

The queen imagined her baby in a little green suit and little pointed cap and began sobbing loudly. In fact, she sobbed so loudly the man decided to give her a second chance.

Pulling his fingers out of his little ears, he said, "I'll tell you what. I'll make a deal. If you can discover what my name is in two days, you can keep the child." The little man paused. "Boy, won't this make a keen fairy tale someday'?"

The queen began pacing the royal nursery and calling to mind all the names that she could think of.

"Are you Henry? Clyde? Newton? George, Marmaduke, Sidney, Frank?"

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"Nah," said the man.

The queen then desperately searched for still other names. She looked in the village white pages, Who's Who Among the Little People, even the gossip column of the Palace Chronicles. The next day she tried again.

"Are you Ming Choi?" she asked. "Or Running Mouse? Cherry Nose? Charlie Brown?"

"No! You've failed," shouted the little man with a mischievous laugh.

"Well, what is your name then'?" challenged the queen, her hands on her hips.

"It's, uh . . ." The little man took off his hat and scratched his head. "It's, uh . . ." Then a horrible realization came to him. He didn't know what his name was!

"Wait here. I'll be right back," he said to the queen. He dashed into the kingdom to see if he could find anybody who could tell him what his name was.

"Do you know me'?" he asked the palace garbage collector.

"No. I can't say I do-and with any luck I never will," the garbage man replied, jumping into a garbage can and pulling the lid on top of him.

The little man asked everyone he chanced to meet, from the village moat cleaner to the royal jack hammer operator, but nobody could tell him who he was. Finally, out of desperation, he went to an old wise man who lived in a hole in the ground.

"No, I don't know your name," said the wise man in the hole in the ground. "But I know how you can find out. Get yourself a mailbox. Sooner or later, somebody will send you a letter. Then all you have to do is see what name is on the envelope."

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That was it! He was truly a wise man-or at least as wise as anyone can be who chooses to live in a hole in the ground.

In any case, the little man did as he was instructed. He got a mailbox and waited inside for a delivery, and before long, he did receive a letter. It was from a talk show sidekick who told him he might have already won a million dollars. But that's another fairy tale. The little man just wanted to see what his name was. But when he saw it, he was shocked. It read "Rumpelstiltskin."

"Rumpelstiltskin!" he cried. "What kind of a name is that? I can't go back to the queen and tell her my name is Rumpelstiltskin. I'd be the laughingstock of the kingdom."

And so, the queen and her child lived happily ever after, for she never saw the funny little man in the green suit again. In fact, nobody ever saw the little man again, because he was so ashamed he got out of the magic business and changed his name to Louie Smith.

And we all know there's never been a fairy tale about Louie Smith. That is, until just now.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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